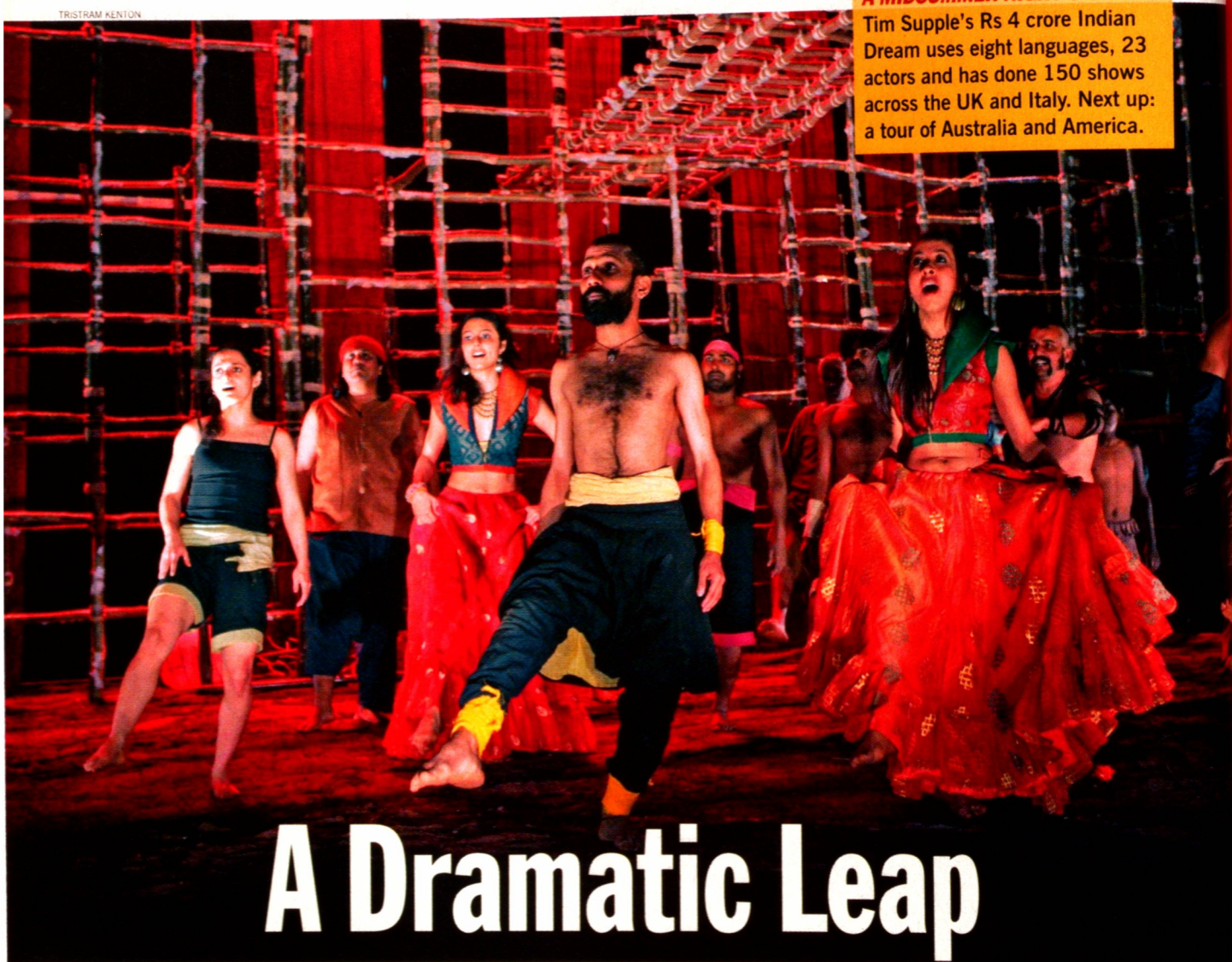


TRISTRAM KENTON

A MIDSUMMER NIGHT'S DREAM

Tim Supple's Rs 4 crore Indian Dream uses eight languages, 23 actors and has done 150 shows across the UK and Italy. Next up: a tour of Australia and America.



A Dramatic Leap

Innovative sets, traditional folk arts and globally-acclaimed performances, Indian theatre has never looked this enormous or audacious. It's an East-West encounter that goes beyond the exotic.

■ **By Nirmala Ravindran**

Two years ago, well-known British theatre director Tim Supple came to India on the invitation of the British Council to start work on a play with an Indian cast and crew. His Indian version of Shakespeare's *A Midsummer Night's Dream* was a theatrical extravaganza, an amalgamation of various art forms like dance, music, acting, martial arts and acrobatics, with only half the dialogues in English—the rest in regional languages. The rest as they say is history. "Tim Supple's 'Indian Dream' set to astonish the world," screamed the normally reticent *Guardian* in London while Michael Billington, probably the best known theatre critic in the world,

rated it as "the most life enhancing of Shakespeare's plays after Peter Brook's." Supple's *A Midsummer Night's Dream* (AMSND) premiered in India in 2006 and has since then done 150 shows, four in India and the rest across the UK and Italy—a first for any Indian production. The production is now back in India for its second run before setting off on a tour to Australia and America. The greatest achievement for Supple's cast and crew has been the impact they have had on modern Indian theatre. Normally used to productions which are considered lavish if they cost Rs 25 lakh, AMSND, which cost the British Council Rs 4 crore, showed the possibilities of the medium. "India was always a big name in the touring

circuit, but earlier the emphasis was mostly on Kathakali or Yakshagana performances. I think Supple's production has made a lot of people look at modern Indian theatre in a new light. It's probably the first Indian play going on such an extensive world tour," says Sasha Wood, artistic director of the Timms Festival in the US.

Wood is both right and wrong. Supple's venture is definitely not the first production from India to tour the world. Veteran Manipuri theatre artist Rattan Thiyam has been wooing audiences in the US and Europe ever since he made his foray on the international scene with *Chakravayuh* in 1985. It won the Fringe First Award at Edinburgh in 1987, the Diploma of Cervantino International Theatre Festival in the